After the Death of Anna Gonzales

By Terri Fields

CAUTION *- This is a Novel in Verse. We recommend checking with your regional, state or national tournament before entering this selection in PROSE. Some states may require it be entered as POETRY.*

Anna Gonzales

(Pg 99-100) "I will slip away,
Making little fuss.
And being less remembered,
which is pretty much the way I have always been.

Never pretty or popular enough to matter.
Never outrageous or outstanding enough
to get attention.
Sometimes, I have to pinch myself to make certain
that I am even real.
Conversations swirl around me.
Invitations to others surround me.
Even Alexis, who has tried to be my best friend,
Is dragged down by my invisibility.

No, I am not pregnant
Not on drugs

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Not alcohol
Not influenced by rock or heavy metal or rap
I am just not.
And I am so tired of trying to be.

So I say good-night to this world
Feeling since it has never embraced me
It will not mind if I have abandoned it."

INTRODUCTION

Picture this: It's the beginning of an ordinary school day. The bell has just rung. The halls are almost empty except for a few students trying to make it into homeroom before they're marked tardy. The day officially gets under way as usual with morning announcements being read over the PA: "Today is Thursday, October 3rd. Volleyball practice has been moved to 5:00pm. The chess club will meet today in Mr. Malkin's room. Congratulations to the JV football team on last night's 14-0 win against the Raiders. Go JV! Student Council will be selling spirit T-shirts during both lunch periods all week in honor of their victory. And now we have a special announcement from the principal."

Principal Barron

(Pg 6 -7) Thirty years in education.
I've broken up fights.
Fired a teacher.
Failed a student.

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But not this.
This is too much to ask.

Thirty years in education
I've learned school law.
Listened to angry parents.
Located lost school buses.
But not this.
This is too much to ask.

To make a difference.
To better kids' lives.
That was why I went into education.
So how does this happen?
How do I . . .

"Mr. Barron, announcements are almost over.
Do you still have a special?"

I trudge toward the camera.
Words caught in unwilling voice.

"I am sorry to tell you of the death of one of our students."

Must continue.
Rumors always worse than truth.

"Anna Gonzales took her life last night.
Our sympathies to her family and friends.
Grief counselors will be available all day."

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TRANSITION

And so, life goes on, but how does it go on? How does one life really affect another? If I am here today and not tomorrow, would that make an impact on your life in any way? Anna Gonzales is dead. She committed suicide. If you could take a notebook and somehow chronicle what went through the minds of students and faculty immediately after that announcement was made, you would know what happened on the day . . .

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Damon Reingold

(Pg 9) The game doesn't always go your way.
I know.
You can go to every practice
Even when your shoulder aches
Your ankle throbs
Your homework waits.
You can do 100 hand-offs
1,000 free throws
10,000 reps
And still sit on the bench
While
You watch Darrith Evans
Slack off
Skip practice
Showboat for Debbie

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And still be part of the
Starting five.
The game doesn't always go your way.
Forget fair.
Feel forgotten.
But damn it, Anna,
You don't stop playing.

Lauren Reynolds

(Pg 21) Since September,
I sat one seat behind Anna in algebra.
Passed papers to her every day.
Studied for tons of tests together.

Though it often seemed impossible,
Eventually,
We always found the unknown for X.

But not this time.
This equation
Bounces against my brain.
And sneers at all attempted answers.

I know I'll re-examine the variables,
And reanalyze the unknowns, maybe forever.
But
It won't matter.

Because, Anna-

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I know I'll never figure out Y.

Y you didn't want to live-
And Y I never noticed.

TRANSITION

According to the Center for Disease Control, suicide is responsible for almost 4,400 deaths of young people each year. The same study speculates that students aged 10 to 14 are more likely to commit suicide than other age group. Even more concerning is that the suicide of a peer is often a traumatic experience for adolescents (many of whom are left bewildered by the lack of warning signs), often influencing other teens who are already feeling suicidal. The following two poems are by students who have already felt the closeness of death – Anna's suicide had a dramatic impact on these vulnerable teens as well.

Kathleen Hays

(Pg 13) My brother was seven
When they told us the bad news:
It was a tumor
That had bloomed in his body
Like a weed.

Seven surgeries, and still he smiled.
We had his eighth birthday party in the hospital.
He said he could feel that he was almost well.
And we celebrated.

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At nine, they said new cells had sprouted.
The chemo was strong.
The cancer was stronger.

But . . . in spite of the pills and the pain,
In spite of the surgeries and suffering,
He chose life.

And you, Anna, who had health,
Chose death.
How could you?

Karen Covington

(Pg 69) Mixed up memories
Of the daddy
Who introduced me to Winnie-the-Pooh.
Who sang every verse of kids' silly songs.
Who whispered the lullabies that lured me to sleep.
Mixed-up Memories
Of the dad
Who cheered my summer softball
Even if I never got a hit.
Who promised I would always be
His most perfect princess.
Mixed-up Memories
Of the father
Who guaranteed he'd be the proudest of all the parents
At my college graduation.
Who vowed he'd walk me down the aisle

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even if I married at forty. Who predicted no one would be a better Grandpa.
Of a morning last summer
When I learned
My hero had taken his own life.
When that was the truth,
Everything I understood of love and safety
Was a lie.
So, Anna, did you know
That when you kill yourself
Those you say you love,
They die too?

TRANSITION

Suicide is a permanent solution to temporary problems. And the suicide of a student affects not only other students, but the teachers and staff at a school as well. You've heard Principal Barron's thoughts already and in the following poem, Ms. Mason, Anna's English teacher explains her feelings.

Ms. Mason, English Teacher

(Pg 61) "Death be not proud."

"Do not go gentle into that good night'"

Fragments of poems I've taught.

Can't finish them--can't think how they go.

Brain too numb to truly believe.

That empty seat in the third row. Anna will be back. She must be.

Quiet, sweet'

A face framed by long lush brown hair. Almond eyes always seemed
luminous. Giving no hint that this unnatural sleep would be her
fate.

I've tried to teach through literature

The wonder of life.

Yet the quiet rebuke of that empty chair

Speaks louder than the most vocal of student skeptics.

I cannot take my eyes from the spot.

"There in the sudden blackness, the black pall

Of nothing, nothing, nothing--nothing at all."

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AWARD HISTORY

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